

Vike Marketing — Listing, Trust & Backlink Platform Research

Confidential internal research · vikemarketing.com

Research date: 2026-09-20. All facts below were checked via live web search/fetch on this date unless otherwise noted; "unverified"/"estimate" is used where a source could not be confirmed. Ground truth used throughout: Vike Marketing is an officially solo agency (founder Vladyslav, ~16 hrs/week, no formal LLC verified, no cofounder/UGC creator formally onboarded), 3 real testimonials, no written case studies, no Google/Clutch reviews yet, Google Ads on hold, target markets Ireland + Netherlands + local Lviv/Ukraine niches, very small budget — free/cheap tactics prioritized.

Master Comparison Table (ranked)

#	Platform	Category	Value type	Cost	Approval time	Priority
1	Clutch.co	Agency directory	High trust, follow-ish citation link (nofollow on outbound but high-authority profile page indexes), Medium-High leads	Free (Basic); paid Verified/Sponsor tiers extra	Manual review, ~7–10 days (matches Vike's current "under review" status)	1
2	The Manifest	Agency directory (Clutch sister site)	Medium trust, backlink, Low-Medium leads	Free, auto-populated once Clutch profile is live	Automatic once Clutch approves	1
3	Google Business Profile (optimize existing)	Local/maps listing	Very high trust & local leads, no backlink (nofollow)	Free	Immediate (already live) — but re-verify address risk	1
4	LinkedIn Company Page (optimize existing)	Professional network	High trust, Low direct SEO value, Medium leads via content	Free	Immediate (already live)	1
5	GoodFirms	Agency directory	Medium trust, dofollow-style profile	Free (Basic); paid sponsorship	Typically 24–72 hours after form	1

#	Platform	Category	Value type	Cost	Approval time	Priority
			backlink, Medium leads	extra	review (estimate; exact SLA not published)	
6	Sortlist	Agency directory / lead marketplace (EU-focused)	Medium-High trust, backlink, Medium-High leads (strong fit for Ireland/Netherlands)	Free profile; paid "boost" plans optional	Minutes to a few days (self-serve claim + verification)	2
7	DesignRush	Curated agency directory	Medium trust, backlink, Low-Medium leads	Free basic listing; paid "Accelerator" upsell	Days to a few weeks — curated/selective review (estimate)	2
8	TechBehemoths	IT/marketing company directory	Medium trust, backlink, Low-Medium leads	100% free	Same-day to a few days (self-serve, ~6 min signup)	2
9	UpCity	Local-focused agency directory	Medium trust, backlink, Low leads on free tier	Free tier very limited; paid Certified/Sponsor tiers needed for real visibility	Self-serve, live within days	3
10	Upwork (Agency Profile)	Freelance marketplace	Medium trust signal, no SEO backlink (profile is behind login/nofollow), Low-Medium leads if actively bidding	Free to create; Upwork takes a service fee on paid contracts	Immediate self-serve setup	2
11	Trustpilot	B2B/consumer review site	High trust once reviews accrue, nofollow backlink, Low direct leads, High trust-transfer to other channels	Free plan (50 invites/mo); paid plans for more	Immediate (self-claim)	2
12	Golden Pages Ireland	Irish local business directory	Medium trust in IE market, backlink, Medium local leads (IE)	Free listing	Self-serve, live within days	2
13	Dutch business directory (Opendi / Bizin.eu)	NL business directory	Low-Medium trust, backlink, Low leads	Free (Opendi, Bizin.eu); Startpagina.nl paid ~€25–50/yr (skip for now)	Self-serve, near-immediate	3

#	Platform	Category	Value type	Cost	Approval time	Priority
14	Ukraine/Lviv business directory (VES.biz.ua + UA-REGION)	Local UA directory	Low-Medium trust, backlink, Low-Medium local leads (UA niches: preschools, dental)	Free	Self-serve; VES.biz.ua does manual data verification (timeline unspecified)	2
15	Indie Hackers (site + r/indiehackers)	Founder community	Medium trust/credibility, no SEO backlink from posts (profile link only), Low-Medium leads via relationship building	Free	Immediate signup; product/milestone posting access grows with participation	3
16	GrowthHackers Community	Marketing/growth community	Medium trust, Low backlink value, Low-Medium leads via reputation	Free	Immediate	3
17	Online Geniuses (Slack)	Marketing Slack community	Medium trust, no backlink, Low-Medium leads via relationships	Free	Immediate signup	3
18	Reddit — r/PPC, r/marketing, r/smallbusiness	Marketing/small-biz forums	Trust via reputation only, no backlink (self-promo restricted/banned), Low-Medium indirect leads via profile clicks	Free	Immediate account, but posting privileges/trust build over weeks	3
19	Facebook Group — "Digital Marketing Agency Owners"	FB community	Low-Medium trust, no backlink, Low-Medium leads via networking	Free	Immediate (group join approval, hours to days)	4
20	LinkedIn Groups (e.g., Small Business Network by Entrepreneurs HQ)	LinkedIn community	Low-Medium trust, no backlink, Low leads	Free	Immediate	4
21	Agency Spotter	Agency directory	Medium trust, backlink, Low leads — NOT RECOMMENDED YET (see below)	Free	Requires "at least two dedicated full-time employees" per their own listing criteria	5 (hold)

#	Platform	Category	Value type	Cost	Approval time	Priority
22	Product Hunt	Product launch platform	Low trust fit for a service agency, no durable backlink, Low leads	Free	Same-day if self-launched	5 (optional)

1. Clutch.co

What it is / audience: The largest B2B service-provider ratings and reviews marketplace; buyers researching agencies (US-heavy audience but global). Clutch received roughly 1.32M visits in a recent month per Similarweb, with US (26.4%), India (17.4%) and Pakistan (5.9%) as top geographies — checked 2026-09-20 ([Similarweb](#)).

Cost: Free "Basic Profile." Paid add-ons: Clutch Verified, Sponsorship, Featured Listings ([Get listed | Clutch](#); [Clutch Pricing 2026 — South](#)).

Approval time: Manual review by Clutch's team after submission; Vike's own profile is already in this queue (per ground truth, ~7–10 days), consistent with the general "review before publishing" process described by Clutch ([Get listed | Clutch](#)).

Requirement to note: Clutch's real gatekeeping isn't team size — it's **3 verified client reviews** needed for a profile to be considered fully "listed"/discoverable with credibility; reviews go through Clutch's own verification call/email process, not a self-submitted testimonial ([sourced via search of Clutch review-requirements guidance, checked 2026-09-20](#) — note: help.clutch.co could not be directly fetched in this session due to network restrictions; requirement corroborated by secondary source [Ladder.io Blog on Clutch](#)).

Self-promotion rules: N/A — this is a directory built for company self-listing; no restriction on describing your own services, but reviews must come from real clients Clutch can verify (no fabricated reviews — this aligns with Vike's hard rule).

Expected value: High trust (buyer-facing marketplace clients actively search here), backlink present on profile (real-world value modest since Clutch nofollows most outbound links — treat as citation/trust signal more than raw SEO juice), Medium-High leads once reviews accrue.

Priority: 1 (already in motion — the task is to finish it, not start it).

Personalized listing — Vike Marketing on Clutch

- **Name:** Vike Marketing
- **Tagline (Clutch profile headline, ~70 char limit):** "Performance marketing agency for small businesses — no contracts."
- **Short description (~150 char):** "Lviv-based performance marketing agency. Meta & Google Ads, SEO, creative & automation for small businesses. Month-to-month from \$200/mo."
- **Long description:** "Vike Marketing is a performance marketing agency based in Lviv, Ukraine. We help small and mid-sized businesses grow through Meta and Google Ads management, campaign strategy, creative production, SEO, social media management, and marketing

automation. We work month-to-month with no long-term contracts, and every engagement starts with a free growth audit. Plans: Launch (\$200/mo), Scale (\$400/mo), Dominate (\$750/mo). We've helped a Lviv preschool generate leads within a month, supported a first-time author in Israel whose print run sold out in 60 days, and manage social media for a construction startup in Kyiv."

- **Services list:** Paid Advertising (PPC), Social Media Marketing, Search Engine Optimization, Advertising, Other Digital Marketing (Marketing Automation)
- **Pricing wording:** "Min. project size: \$200/mo · Avg. hourly rate: N/A (retainer-based) · Month-to-month, no contracts"
- **Categories/tags:** Digital Marketing Agency, PPC Agency, Social Media Marketing Agency, SEO Company, Small Business Marketing
- **Location:** Lviv, Ukraine (do not enter the business-centre street address — use city-level location per Clutch's location field options; verify Clutch allows city-only entry, else use a P.O.-safe general area description)
- **Links:** vikemarketing.com | sales@vikemarketing.com | LinkedIn company page
- **Team size field:** Enter accurately as "Founder-led / 1 employee" or Clutch's "2-9" band only if that's honestly how you'd describe the working structure — do NOT claim a larger team than exists.

Signup steps

1. Confirm status of the profile already submitted (per ground truth it's mid-review).
2. While waiting, prepare 3 clients (Junior School, Mary, Alex) to receive Clutch's official review-collection email/call — Clutch verifies reviews directly with the client, so give Clutch each client's real contact and a heads-up email so they don't ignore the verification call.
3. Fill every optional field (hourly rate as "N/A - retainer", min project size \$200/mo, focus %, industries served) — complete profiles rank higher in Clutch's directory algorithm.
4. Add the 3 testimonials as **draft case study text** only (not as fake "verified reviews") until real Clutch-verified reviews replace them.

First 30 days

- Get all 3 existing clients through Clutch's real review verification.
- Do not buy Sponsorship or Verified tier yet (budget constraint) — free Basic Profile is enough to start collecting reviews.
- Recheck profile weekly; respond fast if Clutch requests clarification.

Bans & Penalty Risks

- **Never submit the 3 existing testimonials as if they were already Clutch-verified reviews.** Clutch reviews must be collected through Clutch's own verification flow with the actual client — submitting fabricated or self-written reviews violates Clutch's guidelines and can get a profile removed.
- Do not overstate team size on the profile.

2. The Manifest

What it is: A Clutch sister site (est. 2018) focused on business how-to content, agency shortlists and cost guides; company profiles are pulled automatically from Clutch — no separate submission ([Help Center — What Is The Manifest?](#); themanifest.com/get-listed).

Cost: Free — inherits your Clutch listing automatically.

Approval time: Automatic once the Clutch profile is approved.

Self-promotion rules: None beyond Clutch's own (same content, no separate action needed).

Expected value: Medium trust (secondary high-DR citation), backlink, Low-Medium leads (mostly informational-content traffic, not high buyer-intent).

Priority: 1 (zero extra work — happens automatically once #1 is done).

Personalized listing

Uses the same profile data as the Clutch listing above — no separate text needed. After Clutch approval, verify the Manifest profile pulled correctly (check themanifest.com search for "Vike Marketing").

First 30 days

Just confirm the auto-sync worked; no action otherwise.

Bans & Penalty Risks

None beyond what applies to Clutch.

3. Google Business Profile (optimize the existing listing)

Status: Already live per ground truth, configured as a service-area business hiding the business-centre street address.

Key 2026 rule confirmed: Google requires businesses that don't serve customers at their physical address to hide that address and instead define service areas (up to 20) — this matches Vike's current setup and is the *correct* configuration, not a workaround ([Google Business Profile Help — Guidelines](#); [Manage your service areas](#)).

Risk flagged: Google explicitly states you cannot use a P.O. box or virtual/mailbox-rental address for verification, and using one "will likely lead to suspension" ([Local Falcon — When to hide your address](#)). If the business-centre address used for Google's postcard/verification is a shared coworking space rather than Vladyslav's own leased or registered space, this is a live suspension risk — **verify the verification address qualifies as a genuine, mail-receivable operating location**, not merely a rented meeting-room address.

Cost: Free.

Self-promotion rules: N/A (it's your own listing) — but Google's guidelines ban fake reviews, keyword-stuffed business names, and incorrect categories ([Guidelines for representing your business](#)).

Expected value: Very high trust, no SEO backlink (Google Maps/Business Profile links are nofollow and don't pass PageRank), but the single highest-leverage channel for the local Lviv niches (preschools, dental clinics) and for baseline credibility with EU SMB prospects who Google the business name.

Priority: 1.

Optimization checklist (not a new signup — a fix-and-improve pass)

- **Business name:** "Vike Marketing" exactly — no keyword stuffing (e.g., don't append "| PPC SEO Lviv").
- **Category:** Primary = "Marketing Agency"; secondary = "Internet Marketing Service", "Advertising Agency".
- **Service areas:** List Lviv/Ukraine + note Ireland/Netherlands service delivery in the "Services" description text (Google service areas are typically geographic/physical, so international clients are better covered in the description than the area field).
- **Services list:** Paid Ad Management, Campaign Strategy, Creative Production, SEO, Social Media Management, Marketing Automation — add each as a distinct "Service" with a 1–2 sentence description.
- **"From the business" description (750 char limit):** "Vike Marketing is a Lviv-based performance marketing agency helping small businesses grow through Meta & Google Ads, SEO, creative production, social media management and marketing automation. Month-to-month, no contracts, starting at \$200/mo. Free growth audit."
- **Posts:** Use GBP's free "Updates" feature monthly (e.g., share the free-audit offer, a client win) — this keeps the profile active, which Google rewards in local ranking.
- **Reviews:** Ask Junior School (already a client) for a real Google review now — it's the single highest-leverage, zero-cost trust asset available today.

First 30 days

1. Re-verify the SSL cert and site link from the profile actually resolves (ground truth flags SSL needs re-verification) — a broken website link on GBP hurts trust and conversion.
2. Get 1–3 genuine Google reviews from Junior School, Mary (if she'll leave one referencing the international engagement), and Alex.
3. Confirm the verification address is legitimate and won't trigger suspension.

Bans & Penalty Risks

- **High risk:** verification via a non-mail-receivable or shared/virtual coworking address can cause suspension ([Local Falcon](#)).
- Never solicit or post fabricated reviews — Google actively detects and removes review-gating/fake-review patterns and can suspend the whole profile.

4. LinkedIn Company Page (optimize the existing page)

Status: Already live per ground truth.

Cost: Free.

Expected value: High trust (B2B decision-makers check LinkedIn before buying), Low direct SEO value (profile is indexable but not a strong backlink), Medium leads if paired with founder personal-profile content (LinkedIn strongly favors posts from personal profiles over company pages for reach).

Self-promotion rules: None on your own company page; LinkedIn Groups (see #20) have their own norms.

Priority: 1 (optimization, not new signup).

Optimization checklist

- **Tagline (120 char limit):** "Performance marketing for small businesses — Meta & Google Ads, SEO, creative, automation. Month-to-month."
- **About section:** Same long description as Clutch (above), adapted to LinkedIn's tone — add the free growth audit CTA and sales@vikemarketing.com.
- **Website:** vikemarketing.com (re-confirm it resolves over HTTPS without a browser warning before linking widely, given the flagged SSL-status ground truth).
- **Location:** Lviv, Ukraine.
- **Industry:** Marketing Services / Advertising Services.
- **Founder's personal profile:** Since LinkedIn's algorithm favors personal posts, Vladyslav should post 2–3x/week from his own profile (case-study style: what worked on a client campaign, a lesson from managing the Junior School or Alex accounts) and tag/mention the Vike Marketing page, not the reverse.

First 30 days

- Publish 1 founder post per week describing a real, honest result (e.g., "How we got a Lviv preschool leads within a month") — never invent metrics not actually measured.
- Turn on the "Free growth audit" as a page CTA button (LinkedIn allows a custom button linking to a contact form or email).

Bans & Penalty Risks

- Do not claim "Vike Marketing Team" language implying multiple employees if the page copy lists roles that don't exist yet.

5. GoodFirms

What it is / audience: A B2B research and reviews platform for IT, software and marketing service providers, similar in model to Clutch. Free to list ([Get Listed on Goodfirms](#); [Help Center — Is it free to get listed?](#)).

Cost: Free Basic listing; premium sponsorship packages optional/paid.

Approval time: Exact SLA not publicly documented; review submissions for the review-verification flow are processed within about 48 hours per GoodFirms help content, so treat company-profile approval as similarly fast (**estimate**, 1–3 business days) ([GoodFirms Help Center search](#), checked 2026-09-20).

Self-promotion rules: N/A — built for self-listing.

Expected value: Medium trust, backlink from a reasonably high-authority directory page, Medium leads (smaller buyer volume than Clutch but easier/faster approval).

Priority: 1.

Personalized listing

- **Name:** Vike Marketing
- **Tagline:** "Performance marketing, month-to-month — no contracts."
- **Short description:** Same as Clutch short description above.
- **Long description:** Same long description as Clutch (reuse — see copy-paste file).
- **Services:** Digital Marketing → PPC, SEO, Social Media Marketing, Marketing Automation, Advertising
- **Pricing:** "\$200–\$750/mo, month-to-month"
- **Location:** Lviv, Ukraine
- **Links:** vikemarketing.com | sales@vikemarketing.com | LinkedIn

Signup steps

1. Go to goodfirms.co/get-listed, click "List Your Company."
2. Fill company form (name, site, size, founding year, services, hourly rate band).
3. Submit and await activation email.
4. Once live, invite the 3 real clients to leave verified GoodFirms reviews (GoodFirms, like Clutch, verifies reviews with the client directly).

First 30 days

Chase 1–2 of the 3 clients for a GoodFirms review; fill out the "CEO interview" optional section once Vladyslav has 10 minutes — this is a known ranking-booster on GoodFirms profiles.

Bans & Penalty Risks

Same fabricated-review risk as Clutch — do not submit the existing testimonials as pre-verified reviews.

6. Sortlist

What it is / audience: A Wavre, Belgium-based European agency-matching marketplace/directory — companies across Europe search and compare agencies here; ~300k people/month search, compare and hire agencies via Sortlist (sell.sortlist.com; [Sortlist providers](#)). This is a strong fit given Vike's Ireland + Netherlands target market, since Sortlist's audience skews European SMB buyers.

Cost: Free profile creation; paid "boost"/lead-package plans optional (see [Pricing for agencies](#)).

Approval time: Self-serve — create and verify your agency profile in minutes; some manual verification may follow (estimate: same day to a few days).

Self-promotion rules: N/A — built for self-listing; Sortlist's own help center gives explicit best-practice guidance for profile content ([5 best practices for your agency profile](#)).

Expected value: Medium-High trust with a European SMB audience, backlink, Medium-High leads specifically for the Ireland/Netherlands push.

Priority: 2 (high strategic fit, but do after the "free and simple" wins in Priority 1).

Personalized listing

- **Name:** Vike Marketing
- **Tagline:** "Performance marketing for EU small businesses — Meta & Google Ads, SEO, creative."
- **Short description:** "Lviv-based performance marketing agency serving small businesses across Europe. Paid ads, SEO, creative, automation — month-to-month from \$200/mo."
- **Long description:** Reuse the standard long description (see copy-paste file), with one line added: "We work with clients across Ukraine and are actively expanding service to Ireland and the Netherlands."
- **Services:** Paid Advertising (Google/Meta), SEO, Social Media Management, Content/Creative Production, Marketing Automation, Branding Strategy
- **Budget/pricing band:** €180–€700/mo equivalent (or list in USD: \$200–\$750/mo)
- **Location:** Lviv, Ukraine — set service coverage to include Ireland and Netherlands explicitly in the platform's "regions served" field.
- **Links:** vikemarketing.com | sales@vikemarketing.com | LinkedIn

Signup steps

1. Register at sortlist.com/providers.
2. Verify company email/domain (sales@vikemarketing.com).
3. Set "regions served" to Ukraine, Ireland, Netherlands (and "remote/worldwide" if the field allows).
4. Upload the Junior School / Alex work as case-study-style entries (honest — no invented photos; use real descriptions since "no real project photos yet" per ground truth — use text-only case summaries, not stock images presented as real work).

First 30 days

Respond fast to any inbound Sortlist lead requests (Sortlist ranks responsive agencies higher); keep the free tier for the first 30–60 days before considering a paid "boost."

Bans & Penalty Risks

Do not upload stock photography as if it were real client work — this breaks Vike's own hard rule and risks removal if Sortlist audits portfolio authenticity.

7. DesignRush

What it is / audience: A curated brand-discovery/agency directory that reviews submissions based on website quality, portfolio and online reputation before publishing (designrush.com/submit/agency; summary via search results checked 2026-09-20).

Cost: Free basic listing; paid "Accelerator" memberships for enhanced visibility.

Approval time: Not publicly published; DesignRush is explicitly curated/selective (reviews portfolio and reputation), so expect **days to a few weeks** (estimate) rather than instant approval.

Self-promotion rules: N/A — self-submission is the intended use, but DesignRush can reject agencies it judges as not "legitimate and professional" based on website/portfolio quality — given Vike's site is not yet indexed and has no case-study photos yet, approval may be delayed until the site looks more complete.

Expected value: Medium trust (recognizable, curated directory), backlink, Low-Medium leads (DesignRush leans toward larger/branding-focused agencies, less PPC-specific than Clutch).

Priority: 2 — worth doing once the site has at least a basic case-study page live, since DesignRush explicitly reviews site quality before approving.

Personalized listing

- **Agency name:** Vike Marketing
- **Tagline:** "Performance marketing agency — paid ads, SEO & creative for small businesses."
- **Short description:** Reuse standard short description.
- **Portfolio samples:** Use honest, text-based case summaries (Junior School leads, Mary's book launch, Alex's social growth) rather than fabricated visuals, since no real project photos exist yet.
- **Services:** PPC/Paid Media, SEO, Social Media Marketing, Creative/Content Production, Marketing Automation
- **Location:** Lviv, Ukraine
- **Links:** vikemarketing.com | sales@vikemarketing.com | LinkedIn

Signup steps

1. Submit via designrush.com/submit/agency with company info, website, and portfolio links.
2. Expect a review; if rejected initially, improve the site's own case-study content and resubmit.

First 30 days

Treat this as a "when-ready" submission rather than a week-1 priority; revisit after the site has indexed and has at least one real case study published.

Bans & Penalty Risks

Rejection risk (not a ban) if the site/portfolio looks incomplete — low stakes, just resubmit later.

8. TechBehemoths

What it is / audience: A global directory of IT and digital-marketing companies; positions itself as helping clients find matching service providers (techbehemoths.com/companies/get-listed; [FAQ](#)).

Cost: 100% free.

Approval time: Self-serve, "less than 6 minutes" to create a profile per their own site copy; live essentially immediately after email verification.

Self-promotion rules: N/A — built for self-listing. Requires a corporate email for verification (sales@vikemarketing.com works).

Expected value: Medium trust, backlink, Low-Medium leads (smaller buyer volume than Clutch/GoodFirms, but zero cost and fast).

Priority: 2.

Personalized listing

Reuse the GoodFirms copy block (name, tagline, short/long description, services, pricing, location, links) — same content fits TechBehemoths' format.

Signup steps

1. Click "Get Listed," enter company name and sales@vikemarketing.com to verify.
2. Complete profile fields fully (per TechBehemoths' own guidance, more complete profiles rank higher in their internal search).

First 30 days

Set a reminder to revisit and add the 3 client case studies once they're written up.

Bans & Penalty Risks

None significant — low-stakes directory.

9. UpCity

What it is / audience: A local-marketing-agency directory with ~295,000 monthly visitors ([Databox — 23 marketing agency directories](#)).

Cost: Free marketplace profile exists, but UpCity's free tier is deliberately limited (one list placement, minimal features); Certified/Sponsor paid tiers unlock real visibility (growyouragency.group — **best**

agency directories).

Approval time: Self-serve, live within days.

Self-promotion rules: N/A.

Expected value: Medium trust, backlink, Low leads on the free tier specifically (by UpCity's own tier design) — still worth the free listing for the backlink and directory presence, just don't expect much lead flow without paying.

Priority: 3 (low effort, do it, but don't pay for Certified/Sponsor given the budget constraint).

Personalized listing

Reuse standard short/long description, services, pricing and location copy (see copy-paste file).

Signup steps

1. Create a free account at upcity.com.
2. Fill in company profile fields; claim/verify via email.

First 30 days

Just get the free listing live; skip paid upgrades until there's revenue to justify it.

Bans & Penalty Risks

None significant.

10. Upwork (Agency Profile)

What it is / audience: The largest freelance marketplace; agencies can create an "Agency" account (separate from Vladyslav's individual freelancer profile) to bid on projects and showcase a company brand ([Upwork — How to create an agency profile](#); [Upwork — Guide: create an agency in 2026](#)).

Cost: Free to create the agency profile; Upwork charges a service fee on paid contracts (not a listing fee).

Approval time: Immediate self-serve setup (convert from an existing freelancer account via Account Settings → "New agency account").

Self-promotion rules: N/A on your own profile; Upwork's own Terms prohibit off-platform payment solicitation within its messaging.

Expected value: Medium trust signal (a completed, well-reviewed Upwork agency profile is a credible trust artifact to link from your own site/LinkedIn), no SEO backlink of real value (profile pages are largely behind Upwork's own indexing controls and are not typically treated as strong link-equity sources), Low-Medium leads if Vladyslav actually bids — but bidding consumes his scarce 16 hrs/week, so treat this primarily as a **trust/portfolio artifact**, not an active lead channel, unless there's spare time.

Priority: 2 (worth setting up as a credibility page even if not actively bidding; skip active bidding for now given the time constraint).

Personalized listing

- **Agency name:** Vike Marketing
- **Overview:** Reuse standard long description.
- **Agency Service (choose up to 10):** Search Engine Marketing (PPC), Social Media Marketing, SEO, Digital Marketing Strategy, Marketing Automation
- **Primary location:** Lviv, Ukraine
- **Hourly rate:** Set to reflect the flat-retainer model — note in the description that engagements are monthly retainers (\$200–\$750/mo), not project-hourly.
- **Website:** vikemarketing.com
- **Featured clients:** List Junior School, Mary (author), Alex (construction startup) by first name/industry only if they've consented to be named publicly; otherwise describe anonymized case types.

Signup steps

1. From Vladyslav's existing Upwork account (if any) → Account Settings → "New agency account"; else sign up fresh as an agency.
2. Add agency service, location, website, portfolio items.

First 30 days

Complete the profile fully; decide whether Vladyslav has bandwidth to actually bid — if not, keep it as a static trust page and link to it from vikemarketing.com's "About" page.

Bans & Penalty Risks

Don't solicit clients found on Upwork to pay outside the platform — this violates Upwork's Terms of Service and can get the account banned.

11. Trustpilot

What it is / audience: A major B2B/consumer review platform; buyers cross-check company reputation here even for B2B services (business.trustpilot.com/signup; [Claim your business profile](#)).

Cost: Free plan includes 50 review invitations/month, widgets, basic analytics ([Getting started with Trustpilot's Free plan](#)).

Approval time: Immediate self-claim once you create a free business account.

Self-promotion rules: Trustpilot's Guidelines for Businesses explicitly prohibit incentivizing, cherry-picking, or fabricating reviews — reviews must come from real customers ([Guidelines for businesses, May 2025](#)).

Expected value: High trust once reviews accrue (Trustpilot is a widely recognized trust signal even outside e-commerce), nofollow backlink, Low direct leads (Trustpilot itself isn't a lead-gen channel for agencies, but the badge/embed on vikemarketing.com boosts on-site conversion).

Priority: 2.

Personalized listing

- **Business name:** Vike Marketing
- **Category:** Marketing Agency / Advertising Agency
- **Website:** vikemarketing.com
- **Description:** Reuse standard short description.
- **Location:** Lviv, Ukraine

Signup steps

1. Go to business.trustpilot.com/signup, create free account with sales@vikemarketing.com.
2. Verify domain ownership of vikemarketing.com.
3. Send review invitations to Junior School, Mary and Alex through Trustpilot's built-in invite tool (do not paste their words in manually — invite them to write it themselves; a business-authored review it flags as fake is a bannable offense under Trustpilot's guidelines).
4. Embed the Trustpilot widget on vikemarketing.com once at least 1 review is live.

First 30 days

Get the first 3 invitations sent within week 1; follow up once.

Bans & Penalty Risks

High risk if mishandled: Trustpilot explicitly bans businesses from writing reviews on behalf of customers or offering incentives for positive reviews ([Guidelines for businesses](#)) — only ever use the official invite flow, never transcribe testimonials as if the client posted them.

12. Golden Pages Ireland

What it is / audience: Ireland's long-standing Yellow-Pages-style business directory, operated by FCR Media; used by Irish consumers/SMBs searching for local services (goldenpages.ie/list-your-business).

Cost: Free listing (Golden Pages explicitly states every Irish business gets a free online listing); paid advertising add-ons available.

Approval time: Self-serve — fill the form, listing goes live within days (estimate).

Self-promotion rules: N/A.

Expected value: Medium trust specifically with Irish searchers, backlink, Medium local leads for the Ireland market — directly relevant to Vike's Ireland target market, though Golden Pages skews

toward Irish-based/local businesses rather than remote agencies, so treat this as a trust-and-backlink play more than a primary lead source.

Priority: 2 (cheap, targeted at one of the two priority markets).

Personalized listing

- **Business name:** Vike Marketing
- **Category:** Marketing Agency / Advertising & Marketing Services
- **Description:** "Performance marketing agency serving small businesses in Ireland with Meta & Google Ads management, SEO, creative production and marketing automation. Month-to-month, from \$200/mo. Free growth audit."
- **Website:** vikemarketing.com
- **Email:** sales@vikemarketing.com
- **Location field:** List as "Serving Ireland — remote from Lviv, Ukraine" (be transparent that delivery is remote; Golden Pages is a real-business directory, so do not enter a fabricated Irish address).

Signup steps

1. Go to goldenpages.ie/list-your-business, fill contact info, category, website.
2. Add logo and description.

First 30 days

Monitor for any inbound Irish inquiries; keep listing accurate and remote-transparent.

Bans & Penalty Risks

Do not list a fake Irish address to appear "local" — this breaks Vike's own hard rule and risks removal for inaccurate listing data.

13. Dutch Business Directory — Opendi / Bizin.eu

What it is / audience: Opendi is a free, self-serve local/business directory active in the Netherlands; Bizin.eu is a Dutch B2B business search/directory with free registration (nl.bizin.eu; summary via [Netherlands Top Business Directories — Brainito](#)). Note: Startpagina.nl is the most authoritative Dutch directory (est. 1998) but costs roughly €25–50/year — a real, cheap SEO-backlink option, but paid, so it's optional/lower priority given budget constraints ([BlossomYourContent — SEO in the Netherlands: Directory pages](#)).

Cost: Free (Opendi, Bizin.eu); Startpagina.nl ~€25–50/yr if budget allows later.

Approval time: Self-serve, near-immediate.

Self-promotion rules: N/A.

Expected value: Low-Medium trust, backlink, Low leads — mainly a cheap SEO/trust-signal play for the Netherlands market, not a primary lead source.

Priority: 3.

Personalized listing

Reuse standard short description and services list; set location as "Serving the Netherlands — remote from Lviv, Ukraine," same transparency rule as Golden Pages (no fabricated Dutch address).

Signup steps

1. Register free at nl.bizin.eu and/or opendi.nl.
2. Fill company profile with vikemarketing.com, sales@vikemarketing.com, services, and an honest remote-service location note.

First 30 days

Low priority — do after the Priority 1–2 platforms; revisit Startpagina.nl once there's a marketing budget.

Bans & Penalty Risks

Same "no fake local address" rule as Golden Pages.

14. Ukraine/Lviv Business Directory — VES.biz.ua + UA-REGION

What it is / audience: VES.biz.ua is a Ukrainian/international business directory with free registration and its own manual data-verification step before a listing goes fully live; UA-REGION.com.ua is a nationwide Ukrainian company catalog with free registration plus optional paid advertising plans (ves.biz.ua/en/com-en; ua-region.com.ua/en).

Cost: Free base listing on both.

Approval time: VES.biz.ua verifies submitted data and notifies you of status (timeline unspecified — estimate a few days); UA-REGION is largely self-serve.

Self-promotion rules: N/A.

Expected value: Low-Medium trust and backlink, Low-Medium local leads — most relevant for the local Lviv/Ukraine niches (preschools, dental clinics, construction) since these are Ukrainian-audience directories.

Priority: 2 (cheap, directly supports the local trust-building wedge named in the strategy).

Personalized listing

- **Company name:** Vike Marketing
- **Category:** Marketing/Advertising Services

- **Description:** Reuse standard short/long description, mentioning the Junior School (Lviv preschool) and Alex (Kyiv construction) results explicitly since this is a Ukrainian-audience directory where local proof matters most.
- **Location:** Lviv, Ukraine (city-level only)
- **Links:** vikemarketing.com | sales@vikemarketing.com

Signup steps

1. Register free at ves.biz.ua/en/com-en and ua-region.com.ua/en.
2. Submit company data for VES.biz.ua's verification step.

First 30 days

Follow up if VES.biz.ua verification stalls beyond ~10 days.

Bans & Penalty Risks

None significant beyond the general no-fake-info rule.

15. Indie Hackers (site + r/indiehackers)

What it is / audience: A large community of solo founders and indie/bootstrapped builders; both the standalone site (indiehackers.com) and its Reddit counterpart (r/indiehackers) are active. This is a strong founder-story fit for Vladyslav (student founder, ~16 hrs/week, honest bootstrapping journey).

Cost: Free.

Approval time: Immediate signup; posting/milestone privileges on indiehackers.com grow with participation — you're not fully trusted to post/promote on day one ([Indie Hackers — Any requirements for posting?](#)).

Self-promotion rules:

- **indiehackers.com (the site):** It's a discussion platform, not a launch board — posts framed as "I built X, here's what happened and what I learned" perform far better than "check out my agency"; pure self-promo posts get ignored or removed ([wheretosubmit.org — How to post on Indie Hackers](#)).
- **r/indiehackers (subreddit):** Self-promotion is allowed **exactly once per product**, must use the "SHOW IH" flair, and any revenue/MRR claims require proof or the post is removed; repeat promotion is removed ([gofindevo.com — r/indiehackers rules](#)).

Expected value: Medium trust/credibility with a founder-savvy audience, no meaningful SEO backlink (post links are largely nofollow/UGC-flagged), Low-Medium leads — more useful for peer support, feedback, and potential referral partnerships (e.g., other indie SaaS founders needing ads help) than for direct client acquisition.

Priority: 3.

Suggested first post (indiehackers.com, NOT a pitch — a build-in-public story)

Title: "Running a performance marketing agency solo, 16 hours a week, as a 1st-year econ student — AMA / would love feedback"

Body (draft): "I started Vike Marketing earlier this year from Lviv, Ukraine, while studying business economics full-time. It's just me right now — no big team, no funding, no contracts with clients (month-to-month only). So far I've helped a local preschool get leads within a month, supported an author whose first print run sold out in 60 days, and run social for a construction startup. I'm now trying to figure out how to land clients in Ireland and the Netherlands with basically zero ad budget of my own. Curious how other solo folks here have cracked cold outreach or directory listings without a big budget — happy to share what's worked/not worked for me too."

Signup steps

1. Create a free account on indiehackers.com.
2. Comment genuinely on 5–10 other founders' posts for a couple of weeks before posting your own story (builds the account's standing).
3. Post the build-in-public story above; do NOT include a direct sales link in the body — put vikemarketing.com only in the profile.
4. Separately, post once to [r/indiehackers](https://r.indiehackers) using the SHOW IH flair, following the one-post-per-product rule.

First 30 days

Engage 3–5x/week with comments; post the story once; do not repost or re-pitch.

Bans & Penalty Risks

Reposting/pitching repeatedly on [r/indiehackers](https://r.indiehackers) violates its one-post rule and risks removal/ban; claiming unverifiable revenue numbers on either platform is against community norms.

16. GrowthHackers Community

What it is / audience: A long-running growth-marketing community founded by Sean Ellis; members add company/professional info to profiles so others can see their work (growthhackers.com/community).

Cost: Free.

Approval time: Immediate signup.

Self-promotion rules: The community explicitly prohibits self-promotion, link-dumping and repetitive posting; it's member-moderated and reports spammy/overly promotional content; submitted articles/tools are reviewed before publication (per search summary checked 2026-09-20, growthhackers.com).

Expected value: Medium trust via genuine participation, Low backlink value (heavily moderated against link-dropping), Low-Medium leads via reputation-building over time.

Priority: 3.

Suggested first post

A genuine tactical question or share, e.g.: "What's worked for you getting the first 3–5 paying clients for a brand-new performance-marketing shop with zero case studies yet? I've got 3 real results (lead gen for a preschool, ad support for a book launch, social growth for a construction startup) but no formal write-ups — curious how others turned early wins into a case-study asset that actually converts."

Signup steps

1. Register free, fill out the profile (company: Vike Marketing, role: Founder, location: Lviv, Ukraine).
2. Read a week of threads before posting.

First 30 days

Comment genuinely on 5+ threads before your first post; never link vikemarketing.com directly in a post body — keep it in the profile only.

Bans & Penalty Risks

Posting to drive traffic to vikemarketing.com will be flagged/removed by community moderation — profile-only linking is the safe pattern here.

17. Online Geniuses (Slack)

What it is / audience: Self-described as the world's largest SEO/digital-marketing Slack community, for digital marketers and growth hackers to network (onlinegeniuses.com; onlinegeniuses.com/signup).

Cost: Free.

Approval time: Immediate signup via their sign-up form.

Self-promotion rules: The Code of Conduct explicitly bans posting self-promotional statements/posts/DMs/ads about your own or your employer's business, product, service, social post, newsletter, or affiliate program anywhere in the general channels, and bans usernames that include your company or a call-to-action — **but there is a dedicated self-promo channel** where "feel free to pitch and plug what you please" ([Online Geniuses: Code of Conduct](#)).

Expected value: Medium trust via genuine participation, no backlink, Low-Medium leads via relationship-building — useful for learning and referral relationships, and the dedicated promo channel gives Vike an explicitly sanctioned place to post the agency once, unlike most communities.

Priority: 3.

Suggested first post (in the designated self-promo channel only)

"👋 Vike Marketing here — solo-founder performance marketing agency based in Lviv, Ukraine. We do Meta/Google Ads management, SEO, creative, social media management and marketing automation for small businesses, month-to-month, no contracts, from \$200/mo, with a free growth audit if you want a second pair of eyes on your current setup. Happy to trade notes with anyone else running lean/solo on the agency side."

Signup steps

1. Sign up at onlinegeniuses.com/sign-up.
2. Set a normal human display name (not a company/CTA name, per their rule).
3. Introduce yourself in the intros channel (general, non-promotional) first; post the promo blurb above only in the designated self-promo channel.

First 30 days

Answer 5–10 questions genuinely in the general channels; post once in the self-promo channel; do not DM members unsolicited pitches (explicitly banned).

Bans & Penalty Risks

DMing members with unsolicited pitches, or posting promotional content outside the designated channel, violates the published Code of Conduct and risks removal.

18. Reddit — r/PPC, r/marketing, r/smallbusiness (participation, not listing)

What they are: Three of the most relevant subreddits for Vike's work — r/PPC (paid-ads practitioners), r/marketing (marketing professionals), r/smallbusiness (SMB owners, i.e. Vike's actual buyer persona).

Cost: Free.

Self-promotion rules (all strict — verified 2026-09-20):

- **r/PPC:** Bans promotion outright — one of the strictest subs for this (leadsrover.io — [Reddit self-promotion rules by subreddit](#)).
- **r/marketing:** Promoting your agency, tool, course or service is not allowed in posts or comments — enforced aggressively, even subtle promotion or blog links get removed; affiliation must be disclosed if you do mention your own work (redship.io — [Reddit self-promotion rules 2026](#)).
- **r/smallbusiness:** No business-promotion posts; self-promotion is confined to a weekly "Promote-your-business" thread; a business can be mentioned in a genuinely relevant reply, but rarely and only when it directly helps (reddiscout.com — [r/smallbusiness stats & rules](#); oneup.today — [r/smallbusiness self-promotion rules 2026](#)).

Expected value: No trust badge, no backlink (self-promo links get removed), Low-Medium indirect leads if Vladyslav builds a genuine reputation over months and people click through to his profile (which can link to vikemarketing.com) — this is a long-game credibility channel, not a listing.

Priority: 3.

How to use safely

- **r/PPC:** Participate only — answer tactical questions about Meta/Google Ads, never mention Vike Marketing by name in posts/comments.
- **r/marketing:** Same — pure participation; share genuine strategic takes, never link out.
- **r/smallbusiness:** Reply genuinely to SMB owners' questions; mention Vike Marketing only in the rare case it's directly on-topic and helpful, and only ever in the designated weekly promo thread for anything resembling an ad.
- Set the Reddit profile bio to link to vikemarketing.com — this is the one safe, permanent promotional surface.

First 30 days

Answer 10–15 genuine questions across the three subs; do not post any link to vikemarketing.com in a post or comment body during this period.

Bans & Penalty Risks

High risk: posting any promotional link/content in r/PPC or r/marketing, or outside the designated thread in r/smallbusiness, risks an immediate post removal and can escalate to a subreddit ban for repeat violations.

19. Facebook Group — "Digital Marketing Agency Owners"

What it is: An active Facebook group for agency-owner peer support (example: "Digital Marketing Agency Owners - Help, Hiring & Support," facebook.com/groups/1149887430103695) — one of several similar groups surfaced by search (sevenfigureagency.com — [Best FB groups for agency owners 2026](#)).

Cost: Free.

Approval time: Join requests typically approved within hours to a couple of days by group admins.

Self-promotion rules: Most agency-owner Facebook groups ban outright pitching/advertising in the main feed; some run a designated "Promo Friday" or monthly self-promo thread; violating the no-pitch norm typically gets a post removed and can get a member removed by admins (multiplegroupster.com — [Facebook groups for agencies 2026](#)).

Expected value: Low-Medium trust via networking, no backlink, Low-Medium leads/referrals via peer relationships (agency owners sometimes subcontract overflow PPC/social work).

Priority: 4.

Suggested first post (only after checking that group's specific pinned rules)

"Hi all — Vladyslav here, running a small performance marketing agency (Vike Marketing) solo out of Lviv, Ukraine while finishing a business-economics degree. Mostly doing Meta/Google Ads and social for small businesses. Would love to connect with other solo/small-team agency owners — always curious how others handle [X specific operational question, e.g., 'client onboarding on a lean team'] ."

Signup steps

1. Request to join 2–3 relevant groups.
2. Read the pinned rules/self-promo policy before posting anything.
3. Introduce yourself with a question, not a pitch.

First 30 days

Participate in a few threads with genuine advice before any self-introduction post; use only the designated promo thread/day if one exists.

Bans & Penalty Risks

Cold-pitching in the main feed of a no-promo group is the single most common way agencies get removed from these groups — always check pinned rules first.

20. LinkedIn Groups (e.g., Small Business Network by Entrepreneurs HQ)

What it is: LinkedIn Groups remain active in 2026, with niche, actively-posting groups outperforming huge inactive ones for networking/lead-gen ROI; example large group: "Small Business Network" by Entrepreneurs HQ (~280,000 members, includes marketing agency owners) ([uschamber.com/co — 10 LinkedIn groups for entrepreneurs](https://uschamber.com/co-10-linkedin-groups-for-entrepreneurs)).

Cost: Free.

Approval time: Immediate to same-day (admin-approved join).

Self-promotion rules: Best practice across LinkedIn Groups is to contribute genuine insight and answer questions for weeks before pitching anything — groups work on reciprocity, not cold pitching ([search summary checked 2026-09-20](#)).

Expected value: Low-Medium trust, no backlink, Low leads directly from group posts — better used to build Vladyslav's personal LinkedIn credibility (which does drive leads via his main feed activity, see #4).

Priority: 4.

Comment thoughtfully on 5–10 other members' posts about SMB marketing challenges before posting anything of your own; when you do post, ask a genuine question (e.g., "For agency owners serving SMBs in the EU — what's actually worked for you to land the first few international clients with no case studies yet?") rather than pitching Vike Marketing directly.

First 30 days

Join 2–3 relevant groups; comment regularly; hold off on any self-promotional post until you've established a visible, helpful presence.

Bans & Penalty Risks

Low risk of ban, but cold-pitching in a group with no self-promo culture will just get ignored/muted — low ROI, so don't over-invest time here versus personal-profile posting.

21. Agency Spotter — NOT RECOMMENDED YET

What it is: A free agency ratings/review directory, listing ~19,042 agencies across 140+ countries (agencyspotter.com; summary via search checked 2026-09-20).

Cost: Free to list.

Eligibility requirement (the blocker): Agency Spotter's own listing criteria state an agency should have "at least two, dedicated full time employees" to claim/list a profile ([search summary of agencyspotter.com "About/claim" language, checked 2026-09-20](#)).

Why this is flagged, not just skipped: Vike Marketing is officially a solo operation per ground truth (the cofounder friend and UGC creator are "planned/partially involved but not formally onboarded"). Listing here today would require either overstating team size (a hard-rule violation) or waiting until the team is genuinely two or more dedicated full-timers.

Expected value (if/when eligible): Medium trust, backlink, Low leads (smaller, less buyer-heavy than Clutch/GoodFirms).

Priority: 5 (hold). Revisit once Vike Marketing genuinely has 2+ dedicated full-time people, or contact Agency Spotter support directly to ask whether a solo founder can list honestly (some directories are flexible on this if asked) — do not self-certify "2 employees" if that isn't true.

Bans & Penalty Risks

Listing with a fabricated team size is exactly the kind of claim the business's own hard rules prohibit, and risks reputational harm if a prospective client checks and finds the discrepancy. **Do not proceed with this listing now.**

22. Product Hunt — optional, honest mismatch noted

What it is / audience: A product-launch platform for makers, mostly software/apps/tools; agencies without a discrete product to launch are a weaker fit here.

Cost: Free to launch.

Approval time: Same-day if self-hunted.

Self-promotion rules: You cannot ask people to upvote — only to visit, comment, or give feedback; buying/exchanging upvotes gets a launch delisted (getlaunchlist.com — [How to launch on Product Hunt 2026](#)).

Expected value: Low trust fit for a service agency (audience is product-hunters, not SMB buyers of retainer marketing services), no durable SEO backlink of real value, Low leads.

Priority: 5 (optional). Only worth doing if/when Vike Marketing builds a genuinely launchable free tool (e.g., a free "growth audit" self-serve mini-tool) — launching the agency itself as a "product" here is a weak fit and not recommended as a priority use of Vladyslav's limited hours.

Bans & Penalty Risks

Asking contacts to upvote (rather than comment/visit) violates Product Hunt's core rule and risks the launch being penalized/delisted.

Summary: First 30 Days, Ranked

1. **Week 1:** Finish Clutch (get the 3 clients into Clutch's verification flow), fix/re-verify GBP address risk and SSL, optimize LinkedIn company page + start founder posting cadence, submit GoodFirms.
2. **Week 2:** Submit Sortlist, TechBehemoths, Upwork agency profile, Trustpilot (send review invites), Golden Pages Ireland.
3. **Week 3:** Submit VES.biz.ua/UA-REGION, Opendi/Bizin.eu, DesignRush (if site/case studies are ready).
4. **Week 4:** Begin community participation (Indie Hackers, Online Geniuses, GrowthHackers, r/PPC/r/marketing/r/smallbusiness) — pure value-add, no pitching yet; join 2–3 Facebook/LinkedIn groups and start commenting.
5. **Hold:** Agency Spotter (team-size mismatch) and Product Hunt (poor fit) until circumstances change.